

DOCUMENT 34

SPONSOR & PARTNER MEETING / CLOSING PLAYBOOK

From 'We're Interested' to a Confirmed Partnership

Purpose: Train Student Fellows and leadership to handle sponsor and partner interest professionally. This playbook covers meeting preparation, discovery, presentation, making the ask, handling objections, defining next steps, follow-up, documentation and the point at which an opportunity can legitimately be called a confirmed partnership.

THE MEETING GOAL

A successful meeting is not simply a pleasant conversation. The goal is to determine fit, decision process, potential support, decision-maker, timing and a concrete next step. Do not force a close when the organization is still learning about the program.

1. WHEN A PROSPECT BECOMES MEETING-READY

Escalate to a meeting when the organization requests a call, asks for sponsorship information, wants to discuss support, requests a proposal, asks about benefits or activation, offers a meaningful in-kind contribution, introduces a senior decision-maker, or otherwise demonstrates serious interest.

Not meeting-ready: an automated reply, generic 'send information,' social-media like, newsletter signup or unverified verbal enthusiasm. Continue qualification until a real person with relevant responsibility engages.

2. PRE-MEETING PREPARATION - 24 HOURS BEFORE

Preparation	Required Standard
Research	Review official website, recent community/social-impact work, geography, audience, products/services and any relevant giving priorities.
CRM Review	Read every email, call note, LinkedIn interaction and referral. Know exactly how the opportunity reached this stage.
Define Fit	Write one sentence: 'They fit because...' Avoid generic statements.
Define Primary Ask	Choose the most appropriate cash, scholarship, in-kind, awareness, experience, technology, media or strategic ask.
Define Secondary Ask	Prepare a lower-friction alternative if the primary ask is not possible.
Decision Process	Identify who is attending and who may still need to approve.
Materials	Prepare only the relevant one-pager, sponsorship deck, media kit, program flyer, budget/benefit information or approved documentation.
Roles	Assign meeting lead, program storyteller, note-taker and follow-up owner.
Desired Outcome	Decide the best realistic next step: proposal, second meeting, internal introduction, documentation request or commitment.

3. RECOMMENDED 30-MINUTE MEETING FLOW

Time	Stage	Objective
0-3 min	Welcome & purpose	Thank them, introduce participants, confirm available time and explain the purpose of the conversation.
3-10 min	Discovery	Ask about their priorities before giving a long presentation.
10-17 min	Program story	Explain the Student Impact Challenge, who it serves, what students do and why the opportunity matters.
17-22 min	Connect the fit	Tie their stated priorities to a specific partnership opportunity.
22-26 min	Make the ask	State a clear primary ask and, when appropriate, a secondary pathway.
26-30 min	Decision process & next step	Identify approvals, timing, requested materials, owner and exact next action/date.

4. DISCOVERY QUESTIONS - LISTEN BEFORE YOU PITCH

Use only the questions relevant to the organization. The meeting should feel like a conversation, not an interrogation.

- What community, youth, education or social-impact priorities are most important to your organization this year?
- Do you currently support youth entrepreneurship, STEM, education, workforce development, scholarships or community-improvement programs?
- Which communities or geographic areas are priorities?
- Does your organization typically support programs through cash, in-kind contributions, employee engagement, media/awareness or a combination?
- Are there particular audiences or outcomes you look for in a partnership?
- What does your internal approval process look like?
- Who else would normally participate in a sponsorship or community-partnership decision?
- When are community, marketing or philanthropic budgets typically reviewed?
- Are there restrictions, compliance requirements or documentation we should understand?
- If there is a fit, what would you need from us to evaluate the opportunity?

5. HOW TO EXPLAIN THE PROGRAM

Keep the first explanation concise. Describe the Student Impact Challenge as a youth/community problem-solving initiative in which students engage with businesses and communities, identify real problems and propose solutions. Explain the current eligibility, submission requirements, awards and program timeline only from approved materials. Do not exaggerate participation, partnerships, media reach or future scale.

Then connect the program to what the prospect just told you. If they care about STEM, discuss problem-solving and technology. If they care about workforce development, discuss career exposure. If they care about neighborhoods, discuss community/business engagement. If they care about education, discuss student participation and learning outcomes.

6. MAKING THE ASK

A good ask is **specific enough to evaluate but flexible enough to discuss**. Avoid 'Anything you can give us would help.'

Cash example: 'Based on your focus on youth entrepreneurship, we would like to explore a \$25,000 partnership supporting student programming and awards.'

In-kind example: 'If a cash partnership is not the right fit, we would also welcome a conversation about technology, products, tickets, travel, services, employee mentors or another contribution aligned with your organization.'

Awareness example: 'Your ability to reach families could be extremely valuable. We would like to explore an awareness partnership that helps eligible students and parents discover the challenge.'

Do not invent sponsorship benefits in the meeting. If the prospect requests a benefit not already approved - exclusivity, naming rights, category ownership, logo placement, data access, guaranteed media, speaking rights or other special consideration - tell them leadership will review it and respond.

7. ASK LADDER - CHOOSE THE RIGHT LEVEL

Level	Illustrative Ask	Use
Major / Executive	\$50,000-\$100,000+ discussion	Major program, scholarship, statewide or strategic support. Leadership-led.
Growth Partner	\$25,000	Meaningful program/award/community activation support.
Supporting Partner	\$10,000	Defined program component, awards, outreach or event support.
Community Sponsor	\$5,000	Local/community support or defined activation.
In-Kind	Variable	Technology, airfare, hotel, tickets, products, printing, food, media, venue, services or prizes.
Strategic / Awareness	Non-cash	Distribution, media, speakers, mentors, professional expertise or introductions.

Note: These are internal discussion levels, not a promise of benefits or a finalized sponsorship menu. Leadership should approve the actual proposal, benefits and valuation.

8. HANDLING COMMON RESPONSES

Response	Recommended Handling
Send me something.	Ask what would be most useful and when they expect to review it. Send only the relevant material and schedule a follow-up date.
We do not have budget.	Explore in-kind, awareness, employee engagement, prizes, technology, services or a future budget cycle.
This is not my department.	Ask for the correct person and permission to mention the referral.
We already support another youth program.	Do not criticize it. Ask whether there is room for a complementary problem-solving/community opportunity.
What do we get?	Use approved benefits only. Ask what outcomes matter to them, then prepare a tailored proposal.
How many students do you have?	Give only verified current figures. Separate current participation from goals or projections.
Can we have student data?	Do not promise participant data. Escalate all data/privacy requests to leadership.
Can we be exclusive?	Do not agree. Record the request and escalate.
Can we announce this?	Only after the partnership and approved language/logo usage are confirmed by leadership.

9. WHAT COUNTS AS INTEREST, COMMITMENT & CONFIRMATION?

Stage	What It Looks Like	Rule
INTEREST	'This sounds interesting.' / 'Send information.'	Keep qualifying. Do not call them a sponsor.
QUALIFIED OPPORTUNITY	Correct decision-maker is engaged and discussing a real support pathway.	Track as qualified; define next step.
SERIOUS INTENT	Specific amount, product, service or partnership concept is discussed subject to approval.	Leadership owns. Document conditions.
COMMITTED	Organization indicates intent to provide defined support, but paperwork/payment/approval may remain.	Do not overstate publicly. Complete requirements.
CONFIRMED	Required written approval/agreement and donation/payment/in-kind confirmation are complete to leadership's standard.	Move to confirmed; activate approved benefits.

10. NEVER PROMISE THESE WITHOUT AUTHORIZATION

Exclusivity; naming rights; guaranteed media coverage; guaranteed student participation; participant/contact data; tax treatment; legal terms; category ownership; logo placement beyond approved benefits; celebrity participation; government endorsement; specific attendance figures; travel or safety arrangements; contracts; scholarships administered in a particular way; or any benefit not already approved.

11. END EVERY MEETING WITH A NEXT STEP

Never end with 'We'll stay in touch.' Confirm: what will be sent, who will send it, who needs to review it, when it will be sent, when the prospect expects to respond and the date of the next follow-up or meeting.

12. POST-MEETING - WITHIN 24 HOURS

Action	Standard
CRM	Update stage, attendees, notes, stated priorities, objections, contribution discussion and exact next action.
Thank-you	Send a concise thank-you summarizing the agreed next steps.
Materials	Send only what was requested/approved.
Proposal	If requested, leadership prepares or approves the tailored proposal.
Calendar	Schedule the next meeting/follow-up before the opportunity goes cold.
Internal Brief	For major opportunities, summarize amount/value, probability, decision process, risks and leadership action needed.
Documentation	Store approved agreements/confirmation in the authorized organizational system; do not rely on personal devices.

13. INTERNAL MEETING SCORECARD

Factor	Score	Question
Fit	1-5	How strongly do their priorities align?
Decision-maker access	1-5	Are we speaking with someone who can influence/approve?
Funding / value potential	1-5	Realistic cash or in-kind value.
Timing	1-5	Is there an active budget/process now?
Engagement	1-5	Did they ask substantive questions/request next steps?
Next-step quality	1-5	Is there a concrete dated next action?

Interpretation: 24-30 = priority close; 18-23 = active opportunity; 12-17 = nurture/qualify; below 12 = do not over-invest unless strategic circumstances justify it.

14. THE CLOSING PRINCIPLE

Do not pressure a prospect into saying yes. Make it easy for the right partner to understand the opportunity, see the fit, evaluate a clear ask and complete its internal process. Professional closing means clarity + credibility + follow-through.

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